

In this context, the 'Development of Solar Cities' programme is designed to support/encourage urban local bodies to prepare a roadmap to guide their cities in becoming 'renewable energy cities' or 'solar cities.' The government has already initiated various programmes in the urban sector for promoting solar water heating systems in homes, hotels, hostels, hospitals and industry; deployment of SPV systems/devices in urban areas for demonstration and awareness creation; establishment of 'Akshya Urja Shops'; design of solar buildings; and urban and industrial waste-/ biomass-to-energy projects. The solar city programme aims to consolidate all the efforts of the Ministry in the Urban Sector and address the energy problem of urban areas in a holistic manner.

Solar Cities, by nomenclature, are those which have renewable-based electrification programmes in place. The basic aim is to achieve a systemic reduction in conventional energy use by 10 per cent over a period of 5-3-1-year. The alternate categorisation would be to motivate local governments in adoption and implementation of new renewable energy technologies. The civil administration identifies cities based on their population, potential and commitment for adoption of renewable energy and energy conversation modalities in the city activities, regulatory compliances for deployment of renewable energy initiatives, resources availability and sustenance activities that have been initiated already in the city. There may be cities which don't fall under the 0.5-5 million population bracket but can be given the Solar City status under a special category notification. Ideally, these are places in the north-eastern states, islands, union territories and hilly regions. Initial plan for the programme was to flourish a total of 60 cities, with a minimum standard base of one city per state and the maximum count going up to five. The plan is to have a centre-state partnership model in

terms of development.

The key objectives of the plan are to:

- Enable and empower urban local governments to address energy challenges at city level
- Provide a framework and support to prepare a Master Plan including assessment of current energy situation, future demand and action plans
- Build capacities in the urban local bodies and create awareness among all sections of civil society
- Involve stakeholders in the planning process
- Oversee the implementation of sustainable energy options through public-private partnerships.

With these objectives in mind, the government is providing administrative and financial support. Demarcations in this case are the assistance in preparation of the master plan for increasing renewable energy supply and energy-efficiency measures for a city, setting up of knowledge groups and system integrator panel for implementation of the master plan, awareness generation and capacity building activities, and above all financial incentives for project implementation as per the MNRE code.

In this regard, the government has identified some cities that fulfil the requirements as per the standards and criteria set forth. These are Agra, Moradabad, Rajkot, Gandhinagar, Surat, Nagpur, Kalyan-Dombiwali, Thane, Nanded, Aurangabad, Indore, Gwalior, Bhopal, Imphal, Kohima, Dimapur, Dehradun, Haridwar-Rishikesh, Chamoli-Gopeshwar, Chandigarh, Gurgaon, Faridabad, Coimbatore, Vijaywada, Bilaspur, Raipur, Agartala, Guwahati, Jorhat, Hubli, Mysore, Thiruvananthapuram, Amritsar, Ludhiana, Ajmer, Jaipur, Jodhpur, Bhubaneswar, Aizawl, Panji City & Environs, Itanagar, Hamirpur, Shimla, Kochi, Howrah, Rewa, Shirdi and SAS Nagar Mohali.

These cities need to take the

following initiatives to create a solar environment:

- Create Solar City Cells
- Constitute a Solar City Stakeholders Committee
- Promote green city culture and green buildings outlook for commercial spaces
- Provide an ecosystem of solar water heating system and tax holidays for users in institutional and domestic sectors
- Comply with Ministry of Environment rules as a civic administration
- Organise fast-paced publicity, training and business meets among various stakeholders within the city, activate RWAs and municipal bodies, and involve private-public partnership in terms of meeting the solar city objective
- Generate necessary funds from state governments and funding partners to meet the regulatory expenses with initial funding coming in through central institutions.

These are great days for solar-powered energy systems. The fundamental steps taken by the government show its commitment towards making a change in the ecosystem and reducing the over-dependence on conventional energy forms. As an entrepreneur, what do you expect going forth?

As leading British architect Sir Norman Foster says, "Solar is not about Fashion, but it's about survival." So I would like to leave you with the thought "Has our country realised the power of resources or it's yet to reach the full circle?"

Feel free to write to me at editsec@efy.in. Stay connected and look out for more in this section.

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